tell Musa I tried!

The news of this third failure broke the wretched Musa. He died. It would have to be, of course, that his bier passed by the goldsmith's house. Standing at the very window, perhaps, from which she had once exchanged flirtatious glances with a stranger, Mohini watched the funeral procession. When Musa's still form was just below, she threw herself down, breaking the chains that bound her in the process. They found her weeping at his grave.

What could the family do? They let her be, 'forgave her delinquencies'. Mohini converted to Islam and died.

'Forgive me!' Badauni writes in conclusion. 'The language of love carried the reins of my pen irresistibly out of . . . my control.'

What is one to make of this story, except, of course, that Musa and Mohini might have suffered no differently in the Agra of the twenty-first century? It was as they died in forbidden love that Akbar had his first son with his Hindu wife, but Badauni draws no contrast between the two facts. Perhaps there is no contrast to be drawn: an emperor's bride was not of one faith or another, she was a queen. And yet, it is Badauni, too, who often cavils at the great influence that Akbar's Hindu wives had on him – as, for example, in the case of the brahmin accused of blasphemy.

Both Badauni and Abul Fazl are personally involved in the story, so it must have occurred after Akbar's return from Bengal, when both men were in his employ. Here is what happened.[16]

A *qazi*, or judge, in Mathura, who had been collecting building material for a mosque, accused a brahmin of taking some of it and using it to build a temple instead. In the argument that followed, the brahmin poured salt on the injury caused by his alleged theft by abusing the Prophet Muhammad – a sacrilege confirmed by Abul Fazl, who was sent to Mathura to investigate.

The case came before Shaikh Abdun Nabi.

Abdun Nabi had joined Makhdum-ul-Mulk in persecuting Abul Fazl's family, and had risen to the highest judicial rank in the realm. He was Akbar's sadr – his chief justice – who not only adjudicated legal matters but also distributed pensions and grants of land to holy men. Akbar was both fond and respectful of his sadr. Badauni describes the emperor rising 'to adjust the Shaikh's slippers when he took his leave'; and Akbar sent his